

Title

Efficacy of Technology-Supported Psychotherapy Delivered in Natural Settings for Reducing Childhood Anxiety: Two-Year Outcomes

Abstract

Internet-based psychological interventions show promise for childhood anxiety, but long-term effectiveness in community settings remains understudied. We randomized 465 Finnish children (mean age 11 years; 71% female) with elevated anxiety to receive either 10-session web-based therapy with clinician contact (n=234) or psychoeducation via digital delivery (n=231). Outcomes were measured at 12 and 24 months using standardized anxiety assessment tools. At the 12-month assessment, the intervention group demonstrated clinically meaningful reductions in reported anxiety (mean difference 4.6 points; 95% CI 2.3-6.9; $p<0.001$). Similar benefits persisted at 24 months (mean difference 4.3 points; 95% CI 1.8-6.8; $p=0.001$). The magnitude of improvement increased from baseline to 12 months then stabilized. Subgroup analysis revealed consistent benefits across anxiety presentations. No serious adverse events were documented. Parental mental health outcomes did not differ between groups. Long-term engagement with the intervention was associated with sustained symptom improvement.